Sujin Lee

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Research and Teaching Fields

Primary fields: Labor Economics, Applied Econometrics
Secondary fields: Entrepreneurship, Household Finance

Education

Ph.D., Economics, The Ohio State University, 2027 (expected)
Dissertation: "Essays on Work Experience, Human Capital, and Business Ownership"
Committee: Audrey Light (chair), Bruce Weinberg, Meta Brown
M.A., Economics, The Ohio State University, 2022
M.A., Economics, Seoul National University, 2021
B.A., Economics, Seoul National University, 2019

Publications

Lee, Chulhee, and Sujin Lee. (2022). "The Effect of COVID-19 Stimulus Payments on Household Spending" *Korean Journal of Social Policy* 51: 60-88. [In Korean, non-peer reviewed]

Lee, Chulhee, and Sujin Lee. (2021). "The Effect of Child Support Payment Coupons in Response to COVID-19 on Household Spending" *Korean Journal of Economic Studies* 69(3): 5-54. [In Korean, peer reviewed]

Working Papers

Lee, Sujin. "Beyond the Jack-of-All-Trades Hypothesis: The Importance of Business and Specialized Skills for Business Ownership Entry and Success" **Job Market Paper,** October 2026.

Abstract: Lazear's well-known jack-of-all-trades (JOAT) model (2004, 2005) hypothesizes that business owners require balanced skills—an argument supported by numerous empirical studies, typically by showing that the number of prior occupations or employers held by workers is positively associated with business ownership. I extend the JOAT literature by arguing that (a) business owners do not need a balance of all skills, but instead need a set of business skills plus specialized skills relevant to their business; (b) business skills are likely to be more important for incorporated, capital-intensive, "advanced" businesses than for "basic" businesses; and (c) evidence in support of the JOAT hypothesis is likely to be sensitive to whether skill balance is measured directly or via orthodox, prior mobility measures. Using NLSY79 work histories linked to O*NET data to measure business skills, specialized skills, and skill balance, I find that all three arguments are supported by the data: business skills are strong predictors of entry into advanced (but not basic) business ownership; both business and specialized skills are associated with higher revenue and earnings for all business owners; and my direct measure of skill balance is unassociated with all three outcomes, whereas an orthodox (occupation count) measure strongly predicts entry into basic business ownership largely because it reflects involuntary job loss. In short, I find that business owners benefit from being jacks of business trades rather than jacks of all trades.

Lee, Sujin. "Can a High School Personal Finance Course Reduce the Gender Gap in Being Unbanked?" Working Paper, August 2026.

Abstract: Among unpartnered young adults in the United States (whose banking status reflects their own financial decisions rather than a partner's) women are significantly more likely than men to be unbanked, even after accounting for income and education. I determine whether state-mandated high school personal finance courses reduce this gender gap, and if so, through what mechanisms. Using the FDIC National Survey of Unbanked and Underbanked Households (2009–2023) and a heterogeneity-robust difference-in-differences estimator, I find that mandates reduce the likelihood of being unbanked for both women and men, but by significantly more for women, narrowing the gender gap by 42.9%. The effects are concentrated among women with no education beyond high school and among Black and Hispanic women—groups that face the greatest barriers to financial inclusion. I find evidence that the following mechanisms help explain these effects: First, the mandates increase women's objective financial knowledge relative to men's, although not their self-assessed knowledge. Second, the mandates increase women's self-employment, likelihood of attaining middle-income status, and college completion rates relative to men's. Because mandatory high school financial education reaches individuals "early" and does not rely on voluntary participation, it appears useful for reducing persistent gender disparities in financial inclusion that adult financial education programs struggle to address.

Gonzalez-Navarro, Marco, Jaecheol Lee, and Sujin Lee. "Restricting Large Firms to Protect Small Businesses: Evidence from Retail Operating-Day Restrictions" Working paper, April 2026; Under review at *Review of Economics and Statistics*.

Abstract: Governments often try to protect small businesses by restricting when or where larger rivals can operate. Whether such policies achieve their objectives depends on how much displaced demand is actually transferred to the intended beneficiaries—a question that requires tracing substitution toward other days, locations, or unregulated sellers—yet direct evidence on these margins remains limited. We study South Korea's policy requiring large retail chains to close two days per month, which provides predetermined variation in closure schedules across districts and weeks. Using high-frequency credit card-transaction data, we estimate that only 18% of displaced spending is redirected to small, independent retailers; larger shares are recouped by restricted chains on other shopping days or diverted to other unrestricted retail formats, many of which are operated by large firms. Consistent with these limited transfers, we find no evidence that the policy improves the long-run survival of independent retailers. Mapping the observed substitution patterns into a discrete-choice framework identified by policy-induced variation in travel time to open stores, we estimate that the consumer welfare losses from restricted access are 2.7 times larger than the gains accruing to independent retailers. These findings suggest that restricting large firms can impose meaningful consumer costs while providing little durable support to the small businesses such policies are intended to protect.

Work in Progress

Lee, Sujin. "Self-Employment Following Job Loss and Subsequent Career Trajectories"

Abstract: Job displacement often leads workers to pursue self-employment, yet little is known about whether these self-employment experiences promote or detract from subsequent earning growth and employment stability. In this paper, I examine the post-displacement labor market trajectories of workers who enter self-employment after job loss, using data from the 1979 National Longitudinal Survey of Youth (NLSY79). Specifically, I compare subsequent earnings and employment stability between displaced workers who transition into self-employment and similar displaced workers who remain in wage employment, using matching methods based on pre-displacement earnings, employment histories, demographic characteristics, and other labor market characteristics. My findings have implications about the potential value of self-employment in shaping workers' recoveries following job displacement. I also examine the characteristics of businesses started by workers who enter self-employment following displacement, including their

job creation and industry composition, to assess whether these businesses generate broader economic benefits beyond individual workers' labor market outcomes. Together, these findings can inform policies aimed at promoting self-employment as a pathway out of unemployment.

Lee, Sujin, Saleh Zakerinia, Harrison Youn, Bruce Weinberg, Tian Lou, and Aiday Sikhova. "AI-Related Education Is Increasing and Widespread but Unequal"

Abstract: We develop a comprehensive approach for measuring AI-related education and examine how higher education prepares the workforce for an AI-driven economy. Using a taxonomy of six dimensions of AI-related skills (Core, Foundations, Hardware, Infrastructure, Applications, and Governance) and large language models, we classify all degree and certificate programs in the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) as AI-related or not, and use these classifications to document national patterns in AI-related credentials. Using data for Ohio's public postsecondary institutions, we apply our classification to university courses based on descriptions in course catalogs, link these data to student-level enrollment records, and summarize patterns in students' AI-related courses. Finally, using UMETRICS grant data at Ohio State University, we identify instructors engaged in funded AI research and examine which students take courses taught by these instructors. By measuring AI-related education across credentials, coursework, and exposure to AI research, our study captures a broader range of AI-related skills developed through higher education than do approaches that focus primarily on individuals engaged in developing frontier AI technologies. Our approach provides a broad understanding of the extent to which higher education develops AI-related human capital and how its development varies across fields of study, types of institutions, and student populations. Our framework also lays the groundwork for future research on how AI-related skills shape workers' career trajectories, firm performance, and the broader labor market.

Lee, Sujin, Tian Lou, and Bruce Weinberg. "AI-Related Human Capital Inflows and Gender Composition in Firms"

Abstract: How does a business's exposure to AI influence gender disparities in its workforce? Building on the idea that AI technology is transmitted through human capital, we compare gender compositions and wage gaps at firms that hire AI-trained researchers with those at firms in the same narrowly-defined industry that hire researchers in non-AI fields. By linking Elsevier data on grant information with UMETRICS data that track payment records for all university research employees on grants, we measure a grant's "AI intensity" based on the AI publication activity of its principal investigators and an employee's "AI exposure" based on their duration and intensity of work on these AI-related grants. We then follow these researchers into the workforce using Ohio UI Wage Records and the Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages to identify businesses that are more likely to have adopted advanced AI by hiring AI-trained researchers. We find that firms hiring AI-trained researchers have a lower share of female employees and wider gender pay gaps (even among non-AI-trained workers) than firms in the same industries that do not hire AI-trained researchers. Our findings suggest that AI adoption can influence gender disparities across the broader workforce, beyond AI researchers and those directly involved in AI development or use.

Conference and Seminar Presentations

2026	Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland-Ohio State University Micro-Macro Workshop; Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management (Fall Conference)
2025	Southern Economic Association Annual Conference
2023	Decision Sciences Collaborative Spring Forum Poster Session (Ohio State University); North American Meetings of the Urban Economics Association; Bowling Green State University-Ohio State University Graduate Student Conference on Population
2020	Society for the Advancement of Socio-Economics Conference (virtual)

Research Experience

SP 2024-present	The Ohio State University, Research Assistant to Professor Bruce Weinberg
SP 2019-SU 2021	Seoul National University, Research Assistant to Professor Chulhee Lee
SP 2020-SU 2021	Seoul National University, Research Assistant to Professor Jisoo Hwang
FA 2020-SP 2021	Seoul National University, Research Assistant to Professor Sok Chul Hong

Professional Activities

Graduate Student Mentor, Department of Economics, The Ohio State University (AY 2025-2026)

Honors, Scholarships, and Fellowships

2021-2022	University Fellowship, The Ohio State University
2019-2021	Graduate Student Instructor Fellowship, Seoul National University

Teaching Experience

SU 2023	Principles of Microeconomics, The Ohio State University, Instructor of Record
FA 2023	Principles of Microeconomics, The Ohio State University, Teaching Assistant for Dr. Darcy Hartman
FA 2023	Principles of Macroeconomics, The Ohio State University, Teaching Assistant for Dr. Darcy Hartman
FA 2022	Health Economics, The Ohio State University, Teaching Assistant for Professor Tamar Oostrom
FA 2022	Intermediate Microeconomic Theory with Calculus, The Ohio State University, Teaching Assistant for Professor John Rehbeck
FA 2019, FA 2020	Population and Economy, Seoul National University, Teaching Assistant for Professor Chulhee Lee
SP 2020	Economic History, Seoul National University, Teaching Assistant for Professor Chulhee Lee

References

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